

be made public. Perhaps to counter suspicions, in 1951 he married an actress, Felicia Cohn Montealegre, with whom he at first lived happily and had three children. The marriage lasted until 1976, when Bernstein “came out” leaving his wife for his young male lover. However, the next year, Felicia was diagnosed with cancer, and Bernstein returned to nurse her until her death in 1978.

A household name

During the 1950s, Bernstein became a household name in the US, not just from his successes on Broadway and appearances with the major orchestras, but because he presented a series of lectures on music for the television arts program Omnibus, with musical examples played live by the NBC Symphony Orchestra. This was a productive time for him as a composer, too, in which he wrote the operetta *Candide*, and probably his best-known musical, *West Side Story*. At the same time, he became musical director of the New York Philharmonic. His schedule with the Philharmonic left him little time for composing in the 1960s, and he did not produce any major work until the *Mass* in 1971.

He continued tirelessly conducting, composing, and presenting TV documentaries throughout the last two decades of his life, despite the emphysema he had contracted from years of heavy smoking. He eventually retired in October 1990, aged 72, and five days later died of a heart attack.